

KEEP THIS ONE; IT'S BUILT TO LIVE ON YOUR DESK

# Prompting Basics: Getting Useful Results Every Time

## THE FORMULA

**Role · Task · Context · Format**

**Then iterate: content, voice, details.**

## The four parts

| Part    | The question it answers                      | Example                                                                                    |
|---------|----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Role    | Who should the AI be?                        | "You are an experienced 4th grade teacher."                                                |
| Task    | What exactly do you want?<br>One clear verb. | "Draft a 45-minute introductory lesson on equivalent fractions."                           |
| Context | What would a substitute need to know?        | "The class has mastered notation but confuses numerator and denominator when simplifying." |
| Format  | What should the output look like?            | "A table with timings; include a 3-question exit check."                                   |

**The colleague test:** before you hit enter, imagine showing the prompt to a colleague with zero context. If they'd be confused, the model will be too. (Straight from the AI companies' own documentation.)

## The spice rack: four small upgrades

- **Constraints:** "under 150 words" · "exactly five questions" · "no materials that need a copier"
- **Audience:** "for students who have never seen this word" · "for families skimming on a phone"
- **An example:** paste one sample in the style you want and say "match this style"
- **Escape hatch:** "Ask me up to three clarifying questions before you start."

## A makeover, start to finish

**Before** "Write a note to parents about the field trip."

**After** "You are a warm, organized elementary teacher. Write a note to families about an upcoming museum field trip. Context: departure 8:30 a.m., return by 2 p.m., students need a bagged lunch and a signed permission slip by Friday. Reading level: busy families skimming on a phone. Format: under 150 words, three action items as a bulleted list."

## Iterate in three rounds (the first draft is a proposal)

| Round       | Ask yourself                 | Say to the AI                                                    |
|-------------|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 · Content | What's wrong or missing?     | "Question 4 is too hard for the start of the unit."              |
| 2 · Voice   | Does it sound like me?       | "Warmer. Fewer exclamation points. I'd never say 'furthermore.'" |
| 3 · Details | Length, level, layout right? | "Shorten by a third; make the directions a numbered list."       |

**Iterate vs. start over:** eighty percent right, iterate. Wrong thing entirely, start a fresh prompt and fold what you learned into the context.

## Template it: your reusable prompt

"You are a [grade/subject] teacher. Create a [number]-question review on [topic] for students who [what they struggle with]. Format: [format]. Include an answer key."

Build once, fill in the blanks forever. Save yours in the staff prompt doc with your name and a one-line note. Nobody at this school solves the same problem twice.

## What prompting can't do

- **It can't turn off hallucination.** Verify anything factual, always.
- **It can't know your students.** Personalizing is your part, after the draft comes back.
- **It can't decide what's worth teaching.** That was never a formatting problem.

**The permanent rules ride along:** no student personally identifiable information in public AI tools, ever. And a human reviews everything before it reaches a student or family.

## My reusable prompt (draft it here first)

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